Week 3

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 1 · LESSON 3

# Truth

## BIG IDEA

Students live in a post-truth, relativist culture that says you can create your own reality. But truth is what corresponds with reality, independent of anyone's opinion. Jesus' claim in John 14 is objective, either true or false, and understanding that leads students to genuine freedom in Christ.

## Key points from the Leader Video

1. Oxford's 2016 word of the year, 'post-truth,' captures the relativism students face daily: feelings and personal belief outweighing objective facts.
2. When leaders present something as objectively true, students often hear only 'that's what you think,' a wall this lesson helps take down.
3. Nothing else this year, Scripture's authority, the resurrection, God's existence, the problem of evil, can be discussed until students understand the nature of truth.
4. Truth is what corresponds with reality, and coherence or practicality is not enough: Santa Claus makes sense to kids but does not line up with reality.
5. Subjective truths, like a favorite ice cream flavor, are about the subject's experience; objective truths, like a shirt's color, hold regardless of anyone's opinion.
6. Culture lumps Jesus with subjective truth, but John 14's 'I am the way' is an objective claim: if true, contradicting beliefs are false.

## SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO

John 14:6

## FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. What is the difference between a subjective truth and an objective truth? Give an example of each.
2. Why do people put belief in Jesus on the subjective side, and why does John 14 not allow that?
3. Can something make sense and be practical but still not be true? How would you tell?
4. How does truth open the door to a life of genuine freedom in Christ?

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WEEK 3 · LEADER VIDEO

# The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

## Word of the year 2016

0:06 Every year, Oxford Dictionary puts out a word of the year. The word of the year for 2016 was this: post-truth. It's an adjective, defined as relating to or denoting circumstances in which objective facts are less influential in shaping public opinion than appeals to emotion and personal belief. So in other words, post-truth means that you don't really need to worry about objective facts, and that it's really about how you feel about something. You don't have to necessarily agree with objective truth, but your own subjective truth is much more valuable. Essentially, this is the word of the year. This is exactly what we're up against, or what our students are up against.

1:12 Every day that they walk into the classroom at school, every day that they interact with their friends and see media and movies and music and everything else that's on TV, this is what we're talking about. It's essentially relativism, the idea that objective truth no longer matters and no longer has any space in our heads to navigate our own reality. In other words, if I don't like objective reality, I can just completely ignore it and not worry about it, and create my own reality, my own truth. You can probably already start to imagine what kind of problems this is going to cause in your own mind and with your students.

1:54 This is also often why we as leaders will stand in front of our students and start talking about something that we think and we know is objectively true, especially what's based on Scripture, and there's a wall between what we're saying and our students. Oftentimes they're looking at what we're saying and thinking, "Well, wait a minute, that's what you think to be true. I don't accept that as true." Even though we're saying that this is objectively true, that this is absolutely true, they don't necessarily agree with it.

2:25 See, you and I probably accepted truth for what it is, even if we didn't like it. Okay, this is what truth is; this is the reality of the situation, or the reality of our environment, or the reality of our lives. We may not like it, but we accept it and we deal with it, or we change it, or whatever. Students will base their truth off of the reality that they create, because they're told that's exactly what you're allowed to do. But it's important that you help your students see truth for what it really is.

## Why this lesson matters

3:02 This lesson is so, so important as you continue to move forward, because you can't talk about the reality or the authority of Scripture. You can't talk about the reality of the resurrection. You can't talk about the existence of God. You can't talk about the problem of evil. You can't talk about really anything else that you're going to dive into until your students understand the nature of truth.

3:28 So truth is what corresponds with reality. When you think of truth, and when you help your students think of truth, help them navigate away from this idea of post-truth and remind them that truth is what is real, what is reality. Reality is really a thing that's independent of me, or you, or your students. It is what it is, regardless of whether we're interacting with it or not. More than just understanding truth and reality is the understanding that genuine freedom comes by living through truth. Because remember, we're talking about what it means to have faith, and we're talking about truth in that context. Our students want to be free. We want them to experience the freedom that is in Christ and that comes from understanding what truth is. And truth is what corresponds with reality.

## Coherent is not the same as true

4:19 Now, it might be really tempting for them to think, well, as long as it makes sense, or as long as it's practical, then that's fine. Then it can be true, right? It can be coherent. It can be practical. It can be whatever. As long as it makes sense to me, then it can be true. Well, that's not necessarily the case. If you think about it, there are lots of things that are coherent. Think about belief in things like Santa Claus, or the Easter Bunny, or the Tooth Fairy. When we're kids, those things make all the sense in the world. But we know that these things don't line up with reality. Parents may spend a lot of time making these things incredibly practical, and yet they don't line up with reality.

5:04 And so it might make sense for some other religious beliefs, or some other ideas that students may come across, that sound good, sound like they make sense, sound very practical. That doesn't mean they line up with reality. It might sound really nice to say all religions lead to the same place, or that all religions have some idea of truth to them. But then what do we do in John 14 when Jesus says, "I am the way, the truth, and the life. Nobody gets to the Father but by me"? Jesus is making an objective truth claim. So either that is true or it's not, and it doesn't matter what I think of it. Either what Jesus said is true or not; whether I interact with it or not, whether I believe in it or not, it's either true or it's false. That's what we call objective truth.

5:56 So if what Jesus is saying is true, that makes every other belief that contradicts belief in Jesus false. We want our students to be able to see that truth is so critically important to furthering their discussions on what it means to believe in Christianity. Students in small group are going to have a really good chance this week to discuss and explore how truth opens the door to a life of freedom. Because really, when we boil this down, understanding truth is more than just intellectually understanding what truth is. It's understanding it so that it leads them to freedom, so that they can be in Christ and can live the life that God has purposed for them.

## Two kinds of truth

6:47 So when we're thinking about truth, there are two kinds of truth that we're really talking about. I've talked a lot about the idea of objective truth, but there's also something we call subjective truth. So there's objective and subjective. Well, what's the difference? Oftentimes this is where our view of truth gets confused, because we mix these two up. So helping to understand these on your end, as well as helping your students to understand this, is going to be one of those

things that helps take down that wall dividing you and your students, and helps them see exactly what it is that you're saying when you're talking about Scripture. So first, let's talk about the idea of subjective truth.

7:26 Well, what is the idea of subjective truth? If I say something like, "I love mint chocolate chip ice cream," but you like another flavor, chocolate let's say, is it true that I think mint chocolate chip ice cream is the best kind of ice cream? Well, of course it's true, because I think it. And is it true at the same time that if you think chocolate ice cream is the best kind of ice cream, that that is in fact a true statement? Well, of course it's a true statement, because you think it. See, these are subjective truth statements.

8:06 They're true because they're based on my experience and my experience only. So it doesn't matter. Two different things can both be equally true at the same time. Two different flavors of ice cream can both be true at the exact same time, because it's completely subjective. And if I'm not here to say it, then this truth statement doesn't matter anymore. So it's completely subjective.

## Objective truth

8:32 On the other side is the idea of objective truth. Now, objective truth has to do with the object. So if you think of it this way: subject, object. The truth statement here is about the subject, and the truth statement here is about the object. So if I'm talking about ice cream, I'm talking about how I feel about the ice cream. But here, if I'm talking about something like my shirt, if I told you that my shirt was blue, you'd tell me I'm wrong. Well, why? Because my shirt isn't blue. My shirt is green. If I told you my shirt is black or white or anything but the color that my shirt actually is, then I'm wrong.

9:23 It's completely independent of my opinion. It's completely independent of my experience. Even if I never bought the shirt and it's still on the rack at the store, the shirt is still the color that it is, until it ceases to be that shirt and that color. So it doesn't matter. It's based on the object, my shirt, not my opinion. This one is based on my opinion; I'm the subject. So that's the distinguishing feature.

9:47 The problem is that what we do is we lump religion over here. We lump Jesus on the side of subjective truth. And we say, well, I can believe in Jesus subjectively, because based on my experience I think it's true, and it doesn't matter what anybody else thinks. And it doesn't matter if you disagree, because somebody else can believe in something completely different and it be equally true. But now we go back to John 14. Jesus said something that is independent of me. He said something that is an objective truth statement, whether it's true or not. So that puts belief in Jesus on the objective side.

10:31 So when we're talking about Jesus, when we're talking about Christianity, when we're talking about the way in which the world works and God being creator and all the things that we're going to talk about for the rest of the year, we're talking about objective truth statements.

They're either true or they're not. And we have to make sure our students understand that they're here. It's not a matter of opinion or experience. It's a matter of reality.

## Truth leads to freedom

10:55 So truth is what corresponds with reality, which then leads to freedom. This is what we want our students to see primarily this week: that understanding objective truth, understanding that truth is often objective, understanding that belief in Jesus is objective, is how it corresponds and lines up with reality. And understanding those things is what's going to lead your students to the feeling and the understanding and the experience of genuine freedom in Christ.